SECTION 2 · STORY 2

WHAT THE BLOOD WAS FOR

The Havasupai Tribe and Arizona State University · Grand Canyon, USA · 1990–2010

The Havasupai are a Native American tribe of about 650 people, living deep in the Grand Canyon. From the 1960s, type 2 diabetes spread through the tribe at an extraordinary rate. It led to amputations, even among the young, and sent many out of the canyon for dialysis. In late 1989 a tribal elder, Rex Tilousi, asked an anthropologist at Arizona State University (ASU) whom the tribe trusted whether he knew a doctor who could help. From 1990, ASU researchers collected blood from more than 200 members. Tribal leaders understood the study was about diabetes; the written consent form spoke more broadly, of “behavioral/medical disorders”.

The samples went on to support 23 papers and dissertations. Fifteen had nothing to do with diabetes; they studied schizophrenia, inbreeding and the tribe’s origins. The researchers saw these as part of the same search for what causes disease: the lead researcher said donors were told the work looked at illnesses “such as diabetes, schizophrenia, depression”, and inbreeding can raise the risk of illness. The tribe saw it differently. One paper suggested their ancestors came from Asia; their own history says they began in the canyon. Tribal council member Carletta Tilousi said: “people got degrees and grants, and they never asked our permission.”

The lead researcher, Therese Markow, defended the work as ethical: genetic research, she argued, often advances through studies that do not seem tied to any one disease. In 2010, ASU’s governing board settled. It paid $700,000 to 41 tribe members, returned the samples and apologised. No court ever ruled on whether the research broke the law. The blood went home. The published papers did not.

They gave blood for a health study.
How much permission travelled with it?